

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Manufacturing English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals.

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

5 Whys

Root-cause method that repeatedly asks why a problem occurred until the team reaches a controllable underlying cause.

8D

Eight-discipline problem-solving report used to contain a problem, identify root cause, implement corrective action, and prevent recurrence.

andon

A visual or audible production signal that draws attention to status or a problem.

changeover

The work and time needed to switch equipment or a line to another product or setup.

constraint

A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible.

containment

Action intended to limit the spread or effect of a problem while it is addressed.

cycle time

The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle.

defect

Failure, flaw, nonconformance, or error that prevents an output from meeting requirements.

deviation

A departure from an approved process, requirement, or expected condition.

downtime

Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

EHS

Environment, health, and safety: organizational functions addressing environmental and workplace risks.

escalation

Raising an issue to a higher authority or different function because risk, urgency, or decision rights require it.

fishbone

A cause-and-effect diagram used to organize possible contributors to a problem.

handoff

Transfer of work, responsibility, information, or risk from one person or team to another.

incoming inspection

A check of received materials or components against specified requirements.

kaizen

Continuous improvement through recurring examination and adjustment of work processes.

lockout/tagout

Procedures for controlling hazardous energy during specified work; actual steps must follow approved safety requirements.

MTBF

Mean time between failures: average operating time between failures for a defined repairable system.

near miss

An event that could have caused harm but did not result in the specified harmful outcome.

owner

Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

preventive maintenance

Planned work intended to reduce failures and maintain equipment condition.

rework

Additional processing intended to make nonconforming work meet requirements.

root cause

Underlying reason a problem occurred, not merely the visible symptom.

scrap

Material or product that cannot be used as intended and is removed from the relevant production output.

spare parts

Replacement components kept available for maintenance or repair.

specification

A detailed statement of required characteristics, performance, or materials.

standard work

The documented current method for performing a task consistently.

stop work

A call or authorized action to pause work when a safety concern requires attention under local procedures.

supplier quality

How well supplied goods and supplier processes meet specified requirements.

throughput

Amount of work, patients, goods, cases, or transactions completed in a period of time.

value stream

The sequence of activities involved in delivering a product or service to a customer.

waste

Activity or material that consumes resources without adding the intended value.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Give feedback people can use

In [specific situation], I noticed

The effect was What was happening from your perspective?

Could we agree to ... and review it ...?

Use a specific example instead of a personality label. Explain its effect, invite the person's perspective, and agree on a practical improvement. Focus on communication that can be changed, not accent or national identity.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Offer a workable tradeoff

We can ..., provided that

Would you prefer ... or ...?

I can take that proposal for review; I cannot yet confirm

Acknowledge the goal and explain the available choices. Connect an offer to its actual conditions. A useful response makes room for discussion without promising approval or resources you do not control.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Production Flow and Daily Management

A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

02 | Lean, Waste, and Continuous Improvement

A team observes repeated waiting for shared tools during a kaizen event. A supervisor blames slow operators.

The observed delay occurs while people wait for shared tools. Let's examine tool availability and layout before attributing the issue to individual speed. Could we test a revised arrangement?

Try it again: The recipient disagrees with your interpretation. Return to the observed example, listen, and revise an unsupported assumption.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

03 | Defects, Scrap, and Rework

A quality report combines scrapped units with units awaiting rework. The manager needs to understand the different consequences.

Scrap and rework are different outcomes. Scrapped units will not return to the process as usable product; rework attempts to make units conform. I'll report their quantities separately.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

04 | Root Cause and Corrective Action

A defect appears after a supplier change, but several process settings also changed. A team member names the supplier as the root cause.

The timing makes the supplier change worth examining, but other settings changed too. It is a hypothesis, not an established root cause. Let's compare the evidence before closing the investigation.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

05 | Maintenance, Reliability, and Changeover

A planned maintenance window conflicts with a rush order. The maintenance team needs to explain the available options to the decision maker.

The rush order and maintenance window compete for the same equipment. Could we review the approved options, expected production impact, and reliability concerns together before changing the plan?

Try it again: The preferred option is unavailable. Offer an alternative and clearly state any approval still needed.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

06 | EHS and Safety Communication

During a safety exercise, a learner notices an unclear equipment-isolation instruction. The local approved procedure must govern the work.

I need clarification of this instruction before the task proceeds. Please involve the authorized person and use the approved safety procedure. I will point out exactly which instruction is unclear.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

07 | Supplier Quality and Incoming Materials

An incoming inspection report cites a dimension without identifying the drawing revision. The supplier used a different revision.

Which drawing revision applies to this delivery? Let's record both references and ask the responsible quality team to resolve the discrepancy before we describe the material as conforming.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

08 | Shift Handoffs and Escalation

The outgoing shift has completed six of eight checks. Two checks remain open, with records attached and a named incoming supervisor.

Six checks are complete; two remain open. The records show what has been checked and what is pending. Please confirm that the incoming supervisor has accepted the follow-up tasks.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

AI extension: build and retrieve vocabulary from this case.

Use the language responsibly

These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Build vocabulary and collocations

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Manufacturing English

Professional audience: plant managers, production supervisors, quality engineers, maintenance teams, industrial engineers, safety leads, supply planners, and manufacturing-adjacent professionals

Scope: These cases practice communication. Actual equipment, construction, and safety work follows approved procedures and authorized specialist decisions.

Lesson 01: Production Flow and Daily Management

Original fictional case: A production line made 840 units against a 1,000-unit target. The log records 40 minutes of downtime; its cause is still being checked.

Language workshop: Give a useful status update

Communication goal: Distinguish completed work from pending work and explain its impact.

Language guidance: Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): We have completed ...; ... remains open. / As of ..., the status is / The next update will cover

Vocabulary: throughput: Amount of work, patients, goods, cases, or transactions completed in a period of time. / cycle time: The time needed to complete one defined production or work cycle. / constraint: A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible. / downtime: Time during which equipment or a service is unavailable for its intended work.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to brief someone who has only one minute. Ask what is complete, what is open, and which open item affects the next action.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: Output was 160 units below target, and the log shows 40 minutes of downtime. We have not confirmed the cause. I'll include the downtime review in the next production update.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Vocabulary in use

1. Choose four useful terms from the reference. For each, give a plain-English meaning in this field, two natural word combinations (collocations), one realistic example and a likely misuse or contrast. Keep the examples consistent with the reference and avoid jargon that does not fit this occupation.
2. Add four related terms that would be useful in a different common situation in the same field. Label these as suggested extensions, explain how they connect to the work, and flag regional or organizational variation where relevant. Do not pad the list with synonyms nobody would use at work.
3. Start a retrieval round: give one short workplace sentence with a gap and a clear clue. Ask me to supply the best term and explain my choice. Stop and wait; do not reveal the answer or a completed sentence yet. Accept another term if its meaning and collocation work.
4. After my attempt, explain one useful distinction and ask me to write my own sentence. Wait, correct a genuine meaning or usage problem, then give the next retrieval question. Work through four questions one at a time.
5. Finish with a short handoff or message task using three terms, followed by two recall questions I can save for another day. Do not pretend to schedule a reminder.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Test recall and transfer

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

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END REFERENCE

TASK: A short retrieval session

1. Tell me to close my notes. Plan six questions: two vocabulary-in-context items, one grammar or meaning contrast, one question about a confirmed versus unknown detail, one short spoken-style response and one new-situation transfer task. Use the supplied material as the answer reference, but do not repeat its existing checks word for word.
2. Ask only the first question, then stop and wait. Prefer a short answer over a multiple-choice question. Do not display the remaining questions, model answers or a word bank in advance.
3. After each answer, say what it gets right and explain a meaningful error if there is one. Accept alternative wording when it preserves the facts and does the communication job. If I struggle, give one clue and invite a retry before revealing a model. Only then move to the next question.
4. Keep a simple record of which items I answered independently, with a hint, or after seeing a model. This records today's practice, not a certified proficiency score. Do not judge pronunciation from typed text.
5. At the end, summarize two strengths and two useful next steps with examples from my answers. Give me a small review card containing three prompts and a separate answer section. Suggest that I revisit it tomorrow and a week later; do not claim you will remember this session or send reminders. Label the final transfer scenario as fictional.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level